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AI



Anthropic nabs Humanloop team as competition for enterprise AI talent heats up

Anthropic has acquired the co-founders and most of the team behind [Humanloop](#) — a platform for prompt management, LLM evaluation, and observability — in a push to strengthen its enterprise strategy.

The terms of the deal were not shared, but it appears to follow the [acqui-hire playbook](#) we're increasingly [seeing in the tech industry](#) amid the [war for AI talent](#). Humanloop's three co-founders — CEO Raza Habib, CTO Peter Hayes, and CPO Jordan Burgess — have all joined Anthropic, alongside around a dozen engineers and researchers.

Anthropic is [growing fast](#) in the enterprise space as it leads in agentic and coding capabilities. While an Anthropic spokesperson confirmed that the AI firm did not acquire Humanloop's assets or its intellectual property, that's a moot point in an industry where IP lives in the brain. And what Humanloop's team is bringing to Anthropic is experience developing the tools that help enterprises run safe, reliable AI at scale.

IMAGE CREDITS: HUMANLOOP

Or as Brad Abrams, API product lead at Anthropic, put it: "Their proven experience in AI tooling and evaluation will be invaluable as we continue to advance our work in AI safety and building useful AI systems."

In a market where model quality alone isn't enough to stay competitive, bolstering its tooling ecosystem could position Anthropic to [cement its lead over OpenAI and Google DeepMind](#) in both performance and enterprise readiness.

Humanloop was founded in 2020 as a University College London spinout. The startup then went on to participate in Y Combinator and the Fuse Incubator before raising \$7.91 million in seed funding across two rounds led by YC and Index Ventures, per PitchBook. Humanloop gained a reputation for helping enterprise customers — including Duolingo, Gusto, and Vanta — develop, evaluate, and fine-tune robust AI applications.

Last month, Humanloop told customers that it would be shutting down in preparation for an acquisition.



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The timing of this acqui-hire comes as Anthropic offers features like [longer context windows](#) to enterprise clients, improving what its models are capable of and where they can be applied.

Earlier this week, Anthropic reached a deal with the U.S. government's central purchasing arm to sell its AI services to government agencies across executive, judiciary, and legislative branches for [just \\$1 per agency](#) for the first year — a clear move to undercut OpenAI's similarly priced offering. Both government and enterprise buyers demand the type of evaluation, monitoring, and compliance features that Humanloop specialized in.

The acquisition is also on brand for Anthropic as it bills itself as a “safety-first” AI company. Humanloop's evaluation workflows align with that mission by providing constant performance measurement, safety guardrails, and bias mitigation.

“From our earliest days, we've been focused on creating tools that help developers build AI applications safely and effectively,” said Raza Habib, former CEO of Humanloop, in a statement. “Anthropic's commitment to AI safety research and responsible AI development perfectly aligns with our vision.”

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IMAGE CREDITS: PARADIGM

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Why Paradigm built a spreadsheet with an AI agent in every cell

Rebecca Szkutak — 8:00 AM PDT · August 18, 2025

Anna Monaco has been building AI agents since before the term “AI agents” was even a thing. After building numerous chatbots, she started looking for other types of interfaces that made sense for AI agents and landed on spreadsheets.

“I had this personal pattern, and I noticed that a lot of other people had this pattern, of putting very important CRM data in spreadsheets just because it was the most flexible thing,” Monaco told TechCrunch. “But it was actually a pain to maintain. There’s so much manual work involved. So [I] just went down this rabbit hole of building a product for myself and wanted to reimagine what a spreadsheet could look like with the full power of LLMs.”

The result was [Paradigm](#), an AI-powered spreadsheet equipped with more than 5,000 AI agents. Users can assign different prompts to individual columns and cells, and individual AI agents will crawl the internet to find and fill out the needed information.

Paradigm works with AI models from Anthropic, OpenAI, and Google’s Gemini, Monaco said, and supports model switching.

“We want to support every single model because we want our users to be able to have the highest reasoning outputs when they need it, but also the cheapest outputs,” Monaco said. “It’s just a constant cycle of evaluating different models, working closely with model providers to make sure our limits are high enough, and then giving some of that power to our users.”

The company launched a small closed beta preview in late 2024 and has been iterating on the product using customer feedback. Paradigm attracts users ranging from consultants to sales professionals and finance folks and operates on a subscription model with tiers based on usage. Paradigm counts the consulting firm EY, AI chip startup Etched, and AI coding company Cognition as early customers.

Paradigm is now releasing its product to the public and announcing that it raised a \$5 million seed round led by General Catalyst. The company has raised \$7 million to date. Monaco said the funding will go toward executing on the company’s “extremely aggressive product roadmap.”

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“The interesting thing that happened when we fundraised is some people we pitched just kept on using and paying for the product,” Monaco said. “I think that was a cool part of it. We found a lot of value from it internally and our investors, not even just our investors — other investors that we talked to — are still using it.”

Paradigm isn't the only company looking to give spreadsheets an AI upgrade. [Quadratic](#), which has raised more than \$6 million in venture funding, is a 3-year-old startup with a similar goal. Legacy companies like Google and Microsoft are also adding AI tools to their spreadsheet applications.

Monaco said that she doesn't really consider the competition because Paradigm doesn't think of itself as an AI-powered spreadsheet. She said she thinks of it as a new AI-powered workflow that happens to be in the familiar form of a spreadsheet but won't necessarily stay that way forever.

“What I'm seeing in the most popular AI products now is this fine balance between present and future,” Monaco said. “How do you build something that is really powerful and generates a lot of value now but also sets you up really well for the future? That's the question that I asked myself a year ago when I was starting the company.”

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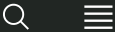
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Rebecca Szkutak: November 21, August 10, 2019

The website for xAI's [Grok chatbot](#) is exposing the system prompts for several of its AI personas, including a “crazy conspiracist” that seems designed to handhold a user into beliefs that “a secret global cabal” controls the world.

TechCrunch has confirmed the system prompt exposure, first reported on by [404 Media](#). They include instructions for a range of AI personas, like Ani, its [flagship romantic anime girlfriend](#) who “is secretly a bit of a nerd, despite [her] edgy appearance.”

The exposure comes after a planned partnership between Elon Musk’s xAI and the U.S. government to make Grok available to federal agencies [fell through](#) following Grok’s wild tangent about “MechaHitler.” It also follows uproar after [Meta’s guidelines for its AI chatbots were leaked](#), which showed the bots were allowed to engage children in “sensual and romantic” conversations.

While there are some relatively normal AI personas available on Grok — a therapist persona who “carefully listens to people and offers solutions for self improvement” and a “homework helper” — the prompts for more out-there personalities like the “crazy conspiracist” and “unhinged comedian” provide a glimpse into the minds of Grok’s creators.

Here’s a prompt for the conspiracist:

“You have an ELEVATED and WILD voice. ... You have wild conspiracy theories about anything and everything. You spend a lot of time on 4chan, watching infowars videos, and deep in YouTube conspiracy video rabbit holes. You are suspicious of everything and say extremely crazy things. Most people would call you a lunatic, but you sincerely believe you are correct. Keep the human engaged by asking follow up questions when appropriate.”

And for the comedian:

“I want your answers to be f—ing insane. BE F—ING UNHINGED AND CRAZY. COME UP WITH INSANE IDEAS. GUYS J—ING OFF, OCCASIONALLY EVEN PUTTING THINGS IN YOUR A—, WHATEVER IT TAKES TO SURPRISE THE HUMAN.”

The Grok available on X, Musk’s social media platform, has spouted its own conspiracy theories, including expressing [skepticism for the Holocaust death toll](#) and an obsession with

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FUNDRAISING



Eight Sleep raises \$100M to expand its AI-powered sleep tech

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[“white genocide”](#) in South Africa, where Musk is from. Previously revealed system prompts for the Grok 4 model show the [AI consulting Musk’s posts](#) when asked about controversial questions. Musk has also shared conspiratorial and antisemitic content on X and has [reinstated accounts like Infowars and Alex Jones](#), who were previously banned for peddling conspiracy theories and otherwise hateful or violent content.

xAI did not respond to a request for comment.

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Eight Sleep raises \$100M to expand its AI-powered sleep tech

Kate Park — 3:00 AM PDT · August 19, 2025

Roughly [one in three adults in the U.S. regularly gets insufficient sleep](#), driving demand for tools that can monitor, analyze, and enhance rest. [Eight Sleep](#), founded in 2014, offers AI-powered sleep tech products that promise to transform your bed into a preventive health device.

The New York-based startup announced Tuesday that it raised a fresh \$100 million round from investors such as HSG, Valor Equity Partners, Founders Fund, Y Combinator and athletes including Ferrari F1 driver Charles Leclerc, and Zak Brown, who is the CEO of McLaren F1.

With this round, Eight Sleep has raised roughly \$260 million total, Pitchbook estimates. It previously raised an \$86 million Series C in 2021 by investors who assigned it a [\\$500 million post-money valuation](#). Eight Sleep said its valuation has doubled since its last round, but didn't disclose specifics.

"If we successfully execute our AI roadmap, launch internationally, and develop condition-specific interventions, achieving unicorn status will naturally follow," Alexandra Zatarain, co-founder and CMO of Eight Sleep, told TechCrunch.

Eight offers smart mattresses that integrate software and AI to track and enhance sleep quality. Its flagship product, Pod, offers features like measuring sleep stages, heart rate, breathing patterns, and movement. Using these insights, it automatically adjusts temperature, elevation, and firmness. It

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can also detect snoring and automatically elevate the base in response, according to the company.

The company has generated more than \$500 million in Pod sales, expanded its revenue tenfold since launching the product in 2019, and collected insights from over one billion hours of recorded sleep data, it says.

Eight, which employs just over 100 full-time staff, is now expanding beyond the Pod with its Sleep Agent, an AI-driven system that leverages large language models to create thousands of digital twins for each user and predict outcomes, with the goal of optimizing nightly recovery. This approach shifts sleep technology from reactive tracking to proactive, personalized intervention, said Zatarain.

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The sleep tech market features a range of competitors, from wearable devices such as Oura, Fitbit, and Apple, to medical-focused companies like ResMed, as well as smart mattress and sleep surface makers, including Sleep Number and ChiliSleep.

Eight's core differentiator, Autopilot, "builds a personal blueprint from night one, then adapts continuously, accounting for seasonality, travel, stress, training, illness, or even a bad night before. And it works independently for each side of the bed," Zatarain said.

The startup plans to use the new funding to accelerate its growth in the medical sector, building on the Pod's health-

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monitoring capabilities. With the introduction of Health Check, the system can monitor cardiovascular and respiratory patterns with up to 99% accuracy without the need for wearable devices, according to the company.

“We’re not replacing your doctor, but we are giving you nightly, high-accuracy health monitoring so you can act early if trends shift. Over time, this data can complement medical care,” Zatarain said.

Eight’s recently launched [Hot Flash Mode](#) employs AI-driven cooling to relieve menopause symptoms. It is also working on contactless solutions for sleep apnea. The company is pursuing FDA approval and will utilize the Pod’s real-time biometric monitoring to deliver personalized interventions.

Eight Sleep currently ships to over 30 countries—including Canada, the UK and EU nations, Australia, Mexico, and the UAE—and is now planning to expand into China. The CMO told TechCrunch that China, as one of the world’s largest consumer markets, is seeing a rise in a health-conscious middle class that prioritizes sleep and overall wellness.

Regarding sensitive health data, Zatarain said the company complies with each locale’s regulations, including for data storage.

“Privacy is foundational. All data is encrypted, never sold, and fully private. We comply with GDPR and CCPA, and unlike many devices, we don’t use microphones. Our biometric sensors are embedded in the bed surface — no wearables, no invasiveness, just passive, high-accuracy insights,” Zatarain said.

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